face. My career and fame were on the rise, and I remember all the lovely ladies I had encountered when I participated in running events across Europe, Asia, and even India, who cheered loudly and clustered around me, asking for autographs or just gazing at me with adoring eyes. I still remember Betty, Australia's sprint queen whom I met at the Melbourne Olympics in 1956. She had never seen a sardar before and was mesmerized by my turban. I taught her how to tie it and even presented her with one of mine. To be honest, I could have succumbed to temptation, but then I would always recall my vow of abstinence, well aware of the deleterious effect sex would have on my mind and body. Sex can play havoc with the self-imposed discipline and practice routine that is so essential for an athlete's growth and development.

Although my sister, Isher, was very keen to arrange a marriage for me, I was really not interested at that stage, simply because I could never find a girl who could measure up to my all-absorbing devotion to sports, or for whose love I could sacrifice my métier, my chosen goal.

When I returned from the Tokyo Asian Games in 1958, the principal of the College of Physical Education in Patiala invited me to give his students a lecture on the Asian Games. I had little experience of public speaking, but agreed even though I thought it incongruous that a young man like myself should be addressing an audience who were almost the same age.

When I took my place at the podium, I began by thanking the principal for the honour he had extended to me by inviting me to address his students. I then narrated some of the highlights of the races I had participated in. Girls were seated in the front row of the auditorium while boys filled the benches behind them. It was here that I saw Nirmal, or Nimmi as she was affectionately called, again. She was talking animatedly to her friends, and I presumed somehow that I was the subject of her witty comments. After my lecture, several girls and boys came up to me for autographs or to be photographed with me, but Nimmi remained aloof. Perhaps she was too shy, or too proud to join the crowd. I saw her staring at me but lacked the courage to single her out for a chat so that we could renew our acquaintance.

There had been an innocence in my experience with the fairer sex so far, but I soon realized how convoluted the mating game could be. It was at an exhibition on Mathura Road in Delhi when I first set eyes on one of the most striking young ladies I had ever seen. As a joke, a friend said, 'Milkha,